

Recovering After Surgery

Pain control, wound care, bathing, and activity guidance for your first weeks at home.

Pain Control

- Some soreness, and even shoulder or neck pain from the gas used during surgery, is normal and improves over a few days.
- Take prescribed and/or over-the-counter pain relievers exactly as directed by your care team.
- If you're given a stronger prescription pain medication, do not drive or operate machinery while taking it.
- Call your care team if your pain isn't controlled by your medication, or if it suddenly gets worse.

Wound Care

You'll have 3–4 small incisions, likely covered with steri-strips and a shower-proof outer dressing.

- Keep the outer dressing dry for the first 48 hours.
- After 48 hours, you can typically remove the outer dressing, following your team's specific instructions.
- Steri-strips usually loosen and fall off on their own within about a week — don't peel them off early.
- Watch for redness, swelling, warmth, pus, or a bad odor at an incision, and call your care team if you notice any of these.

Bathing

- Showering is usually fine about 24–48 hours after surgery — confirm the exact timing with your team.
- Gently pat incisions dry afterward; don't rub.
- Avoid baths, hot tubs, swimming pools, or soaking your incisions for about a week, or until your team confirms the wounds are fully closed.
- Avoid scented soaps, lotions, or powders directly on the incisions until they've healed.

Activity

- Expect to feel tired for the first few days — that's normal.
- Rest, but don't stay in bed all day. Short, gentle walks help prevent complications and can ease gas-related discomfort.
- Gradually increase activity over 1–2 weeks as you feel able.
- Avoid heavy lifting (roughly more than 10 pounds) and strenuous exercise for about 4–6 weeks, or until your surgeon clears you.
- Don't drive until you're off prescription pain medication and can comfortably brake or react without pain.

- Many people return to desk-type work in about 1–2 weeks; physically demanding jobs may need longer — ask your surgeon what's right for your situation.

Diet

Start with light, easy-to-digest foods and plenty of water. Fatty or greasy foods may be harder to tolerate for the first few weeks after surgery — this typically improves with time.

Call Your Care Team Promptly, or Seek Emergency Care, If You Notice

- A fever
- Increasing redness, swelling, or pus at an incision
- An incision that reopens
- Worsening pain that your medication doesn't relieve
- Persistent nausea or vomiting
- Yellowing of your skin or eyes
- Inability to urinate
- Heavy bleeding

For urgent or severe symptoms, go to the nearest emergency department rather than waiting for a callback.

This information is general education about a common procedure and does not replace advice from your own surgeon and care team. Instructions can vary by patient — always follow what your care team tells you, and call them with any questions or concerns.